

Eigenvalues and inverse problems

The Euclidean distance degree of the real symplectic group

Difficulty: challenging **Importance:** interesting to the community

Status: explicit proposed formula for an open problem; no resolution located

For each $m \geq 1$, set

$$J = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & I_m \\ -I_m & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathrm{Sp}_{2m}(\mathbb{C}) = \{X \in \mathbb{C}^{2m \times 2m} : X^T J X = J\}.$$

For a generic data matrix $U \in \mathbb{C}^{2m \times 2m}$, let D_m be the number of complex critical points on this variety of

$$f_U(X) = \mathrm{tr}((X - U)^T (X - U)).$$

This is the complexification of squared real Frobenius distance; the transpose is not a conjugate transpose. Equivalently, count the solutions X of $X^T J X = J$ and

$$\mathrm{tr}((U - X)^T X H) = 0 \quad \text{for every } H \in \mathbb{C}^{2m \times 2m} \text{ satisfying } H^T J + J H = 0.$$

“Generic” means outside a proper Zariski-closed set where the finite critical-point count can change. Is

$$D_m = 2^{m^2} + 2^{2m-1} \quad \text{for every } m \geq 1?$$

Relevance

D_m measures the algebraic complexity of finding the nearest real symplectic matrix. This is a structured matrix nearness problem, relevant when numerical approximations should preserve a symplectic form. The standard Frobenius inner product and the displayed J are part of the problem.

References

- J. A. Baaijens and J. Draisma, *Euclidean distance degrees of real algebraic groups*, Linear Algebra and its Applications 467 (2015), 174–187, §5, p.187: proposed formula immediately before Problem 5.1; §2 for critical equations ([version of record](#); [journal](#)).
- Z. Lai, L.-H. Lim, and K. Ye, *Euclidean Distance Degree in Manifold Optimization*, SIAM Journal on Optimization 35 (2025), 2402–2422, related ED-degree results for flag, Grassmann, and Stiefel models ([journal](#)).

Status check — 2026-09-08

The source computed $D_1 = 4$, $D_2 = 24$, and $D_3 = 544$, and explicitly proposed the displayed pattern. It did not assert a proof. Searches for “symplectic group”, “Euclidean distance degree”, “ED degree”, “544”, and 2024–2026 found no proof, counterexample, or additional general formula. The 2025 related article’s abstract treats different manifold families. No recent explicit reaffirmation of this exact formula was located.